shown how this region became a major recruiting ground for ‘peasant-soldiers’ over several centuries, serving Sher Shah Suri, the Mughal army, the British, and other local rulers, zamindars and warlords.[18] Some migrants were recruited into Robert Clive’s sepoy battalions in Bengal in the 1770s and the district was providing over 10,000 sepoys by the mid-19th century.[19] It is possible that harsh rents and unsuitable conditions of indigo cultivation prompted peasants to look at options beyond the district in the early 19th century.[20] It is possible that this was triggered by streams of emigration to plantations in Mauritius and the Caribbean islands, for which recruitment took place in the mid-19th century. Be that as it may, by the late 19th century, colonial officials were noting the ‘usual exodus’ of not thousands but hundreds of thousands of migrant workers comprising over 15 per cent of the district’s population going *purab* or east.[21] By 1901, Saran’s sex ratio had risen to 1200 females per 1000 males, reflecting mass male outmigration as workers headed towards opportunities in ‘mills, factories, docks and coal mines, or on the roads and railways, or in harvesting the crops of other districts’.[22] These opportunities lay in various parts of Bengal (including present-day Bangladesh), from Darjeeling in the north to Kolkata in the south and offered daily wages that were three to five times higher than what was available in Saran. Migration peaked between November and May which was the slack season in the agricultural calendar of Saran. Initially, migrants would ‘tramp every foot of the way out and home’ taking one or two months to reach their destinations.[23] With the advent of the railway line linking north Bihar to Kolkata, the volume and flexibility of migration streams grew as travel time was shortened to a few days.

Migration from Saran affected all the numerically significant castes—Brahmins, Rajputs, Ahirs, Koiris, Kurmis and Chamars—as well as Muslim communities. The occupations, however, varied with the upper castes being predominantly engaged in service professions in towns and cities and the lowest castes working predominantly as agricultural labourers. The jute mill towns that sprung up around Kolkata became an important destination for Saran’s migrant workers in the 20th century. Migrant networks were crucial